interference in the internal affairs of its member states. But this time there is growing awareness that a problem that has the capacity to destabilise the region is the deliberate result of Myanmar's domestic policies. In early 2015 ASEAN parliamentarians have concluded that there is 'a high risk of genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity' in Rakhine, and later added that 'The situation … has only deteriorated since. Disenfranchisement, combined with economic depression, lack of access to livelihoods, and dire humanitarian conditions, will drive increasing numbers of Rohingya to flee the country'.[71]

It is now quite clear that there will be further refugee crises unless Myanmar reduces the persecution of the Rohingyas. Such crises will be marked by significant payments to people smugglers, violence, death and slave labour (or at best unprotected labour) in the wider region. Neighbouring states can mitigate the worst of this by abiding by the UN conventions on protection of refugees, but the blame lies squarely with the policies of the Myanmar government. But meeting obligations under the UN conventions is not just a matter for the ASEAN nations. Australia persists in refusing to accept any refugees from Myanmar[72] either directly or as part of a wider programme of resettlement.

Terrorism

A regular motif in the extremist Buddhist narrative is the alleged close links between the Rohingyas and states such as Saudi Arabia, or armed jihadist groups such as Al-Qaeda or ISIS.[73] So far, there is no evidence that such links, if they exist, have led to jihadist violence within Myanmar. A local Rohingya group, the Unity for Peace Network, has taken the step of issuing a strict interpretation of what is meant by jihad, the role of mosques and certain Koranic verses.[74] This might be seen as a deliberate attempt to remove the justifications often used by violent jihadist movements that their acts are justified by the Koran and Hadith.

However, the plight of the Rohingyas is now desperate and there has to be a serious question as to how much longer the Rohingyas will wait for intervention on their behalf before they decide that any intervention on their behalf will do—even one from Al-Qaeda or ISIS. So far, any such interventions, even if they are truly linked to Islamist extremism, have been